

30 Minutes Expert

Lap Sync

Fed up of manual file transfers after tedious business trips? Get in sync ...

You've just returned from a business trip, and start the process of transferring files from your laptop to your PC. With fingers and toes crossed, you pray that everything goes well. As you even sit and search through folders, to see which files aren't already on the PC, you contemplate quitting your job. Fortunately for you, we've got a simple solution. All you need do is let Windows XP's Offline files feature help you out of this predicament.

STEP 9 Enabling offline files

First, go to **Control Panel > User Accounts > Change the way users log on or off** and uncheck 'Fast User Switching'. Next, open My Computer, and go to **Tools > Folder Options**. Switch to the Offline Files tab, and ensure that 'Enable Offline Files' is ticked. Here, you'll also find options that let you decide about synchronising while logging on and off. Note that these affect all the network drives you set for synchronisation.

STEP 10 Map network drives

It's time now to create a network drive. Map a shared folder over the network using a drive letter. On the laptop, open My Computer, and click **Tools > Map Network Drive**, choose a drive letter, and enter '**\\computername\sharedfolder**', where '**computername**' is the name of your desktop PC, and '**sharedfolder**' is the folder you've shared on the desktop computer. This folder should have read and write access in order to synchronise.

STEP 11 Networking offline

Click on the networked drive in My Computer and go to **File > Make Available Offline**. A wizard lets you set further options when you do this for the first time. This option is available only by going through the aforementioned path. To disable synchronization for a mapped drive, select

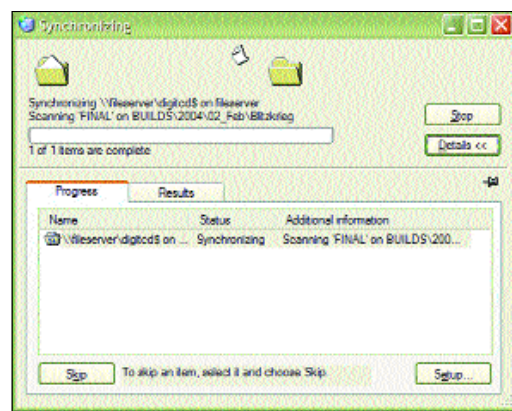
the drive in My Computer, and go to **File > Make Available Offline** and remove the checkmark.

STEP 12 Synchronising

When you first make a network drive available offline, all the files are downloaded from your laptop to your desktop PC. Whenever you re-plug the laptop to the network and log on to Windows, the network drive is synchronised. Synchronisation is done based on the date the file was last modified. Say you created a file in offline mode, named 'somefile.txt,' on May 25, 2004, which was not accessed thereafter. Say another user created a file with the same name in the target folder on the desktop on May 26, 2004.

If you plug your laptop into the

Find it on the Mindware CD
Second Copy 2000



The Synchronisation Manager gives details of the process

> **Synchronize**, or just enter '**mobsync**' in the Run dialog box. Here, you'll see a number of network drives, as well as Offline Web pages to be synchronized. Select an item and click Setup. There are three tabs where you can specify when to synchronize. The Logon/Logoff tab lets you decide about synchronizing while logging on or off. Use the On Idle tab for synchronising when the computer is not in use. In the Schedule tab, set the time at which synchronization should start automatically.

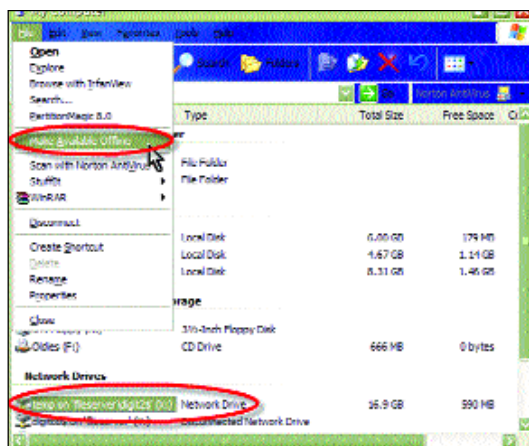
The third-party way

Third-party software such as Second Copy (www.centered.com), Folder Match (www.foldermatch.com), etc., also help you orchestrate harmony between your laptop and desktop PC. They also throw in some nifty features such as mass file renamers and duplicate file finders.

Synchronisation saves a lot of grief when maintaining that much-needed accord amongst your work files. Say goodbye to those backbreaking data transfer days of yore!

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Drives available offline get synchronized once you plug the laptop into the network

network after the 26th, the file on the desktop replaces the one on your laptop.

STEP 13 Synchronisation Manager

Access the Synchronisation Manager by going to **Start > All Programs > Accessories**